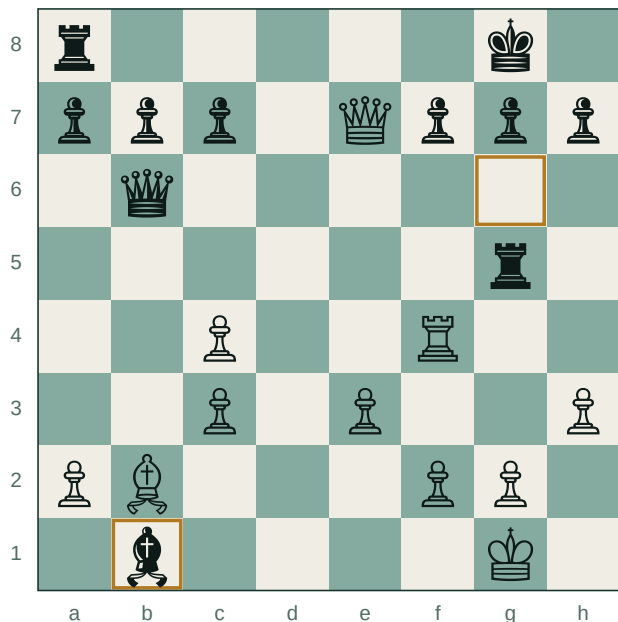


Back-rank mates: White, move 23

Back-rank mates

White to move



Previous move: 22...Bxb1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23. Qxf7+ Kh8 24. Qf8+ Rxf8 25. Rxf8#

23.Qxf7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on f7. Recorded reply: **23...Kh8**.

24.Qf8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From f8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **24...Rxf8**.

25.Rxf8# Mate: rook on f8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A king trapped behind its own pawns may have no flight square when a rook or queen reaches its back rank. The entry square and its defenders are critical.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and rook on g5. Check for tactical protection.